

bigger than cricket. If the base of the game is weak, you cannot keep expecting the top to remain strong.

The connection between the domestic game and the public has weakened, too.

A few years ago, if you went down the main street, there would be people playing cricket. You couldn't take your car through without getting hit by a cricket ball. Wherever they found an empty space, they were playing. That is not the case anymore. You hardly see any crowds at cricket matches.

I have seen something similar happen in England.

In the late 1980s and 1990s, England were not winning enough matches. People started losing interest and clubs began to merge. Then England won the Ashes in 2005, and cricket started competing with rugby and football again.

That is probably what is happening in Pakistan. The national team is not doing too well, and people are fed up with the chopping and changing of cricket boards.

There is no direction. So people are trying to opt out.

Players need a pathway, not just a place in the squad

When Gary Kirsten and Jason Gillespie were booted out, there was much hue and cry. I am not against foreign coaches. All my life, I have coached outside Pakistan, so I cannot say they shouldn't be allowed. If they are good enough and good for the team, they should manage any team in the world.

But they have to spend time in Pakistan.

When you are on tour, you see players performing and underperforming. But you also need to watch domestic cricket and know your bench strength.

Unfortunately, the Pakistan Cricket Board is not very keen on sending the A team and the Under-19 team abroad. They have not been spending enough time on

the development of the game.

In 1978, we went to England with a very young side and without much in the way of backup. We were all very young. I was one of the main bowlers, which tells you something about the standard of our bowling attack. We struggled against Chris Old, Mike Hendrick and the other specialist bowlers in those conditions. It was a two-match Test series, which we lost 0-2.

Most of the players who went on that tour became household names later. Sadiq Mohammad, Mohsin

Out in the cold: Mohammad Rizwan (in pic) and Imam-ul-Haq appear unlikely to figure prominently in Pakistan's plans in the near future.

GETTY IMAGES

Khan, Javed Miandad, Wasim Raja, Sarfaraz Nawaz, Sikandar Bakht, Wasim Bari, Iqbal Qasim — most of them were youngsters then. That was one dividend the tour paid. We were exposed to international cricket early, and those players went on to develop.

Today, we finish up with a squad of about 20 to 25 players and keep rotating those players. That is not how it should be.

As soon as a Pakistan tour finishes, the players should go and play First-Class cricket. Come January and February, they must take an A team. It should consist of players who have come from domestic cricket. Those players never get the exposure before they play for Pakistan. All of a sudden, there is such a vast gulf, and then they struggle.

I pick up the paper every morning and see India U-19 playing South Africa and Australia. I see Australia playing India and England. England Lions and U-19 teams are going to South Africa. Bangladesh has been very busy with its U-19 programme.

Pakistan hardly tours at that level.

First-Class cricket cannot be optional

The team's dismal performance in England has opened a can of worms. It was no match for England, but one must remember that the white-ball economy has changed cricket all over the world. In Pakistan, though, the connection with domestic cricket has been lost. Pakistani players don't like playing domestic cricket. They don't want

